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THA 162: Basic Theatre Administration and Management

Budgets, schedules, people and the business of putting on a show

THEATRE & FILM

Theatre & Film Studies

Faculty of Arts
Theatre & Film Studies | 100L

OUTLINE ARCHIVE: 2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Why this pack exists

Productions fail on logistics more often than on talent. This pack covers organisational structures, budgeting and break-even, scheduling, front-of-house and box office, contracts and basic stage management paperwork, with templates you can adapt for a campus production.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Describe the structure of a theatre organisation and who reports to whom.
- Prepare a simple production budget and calculate break-even attendance.
- Build a rehearsal and production schedule with dependencies.
- Explain the stage manager's paperwork and communication role.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Structure and governance

A theatre company is an organisation with money, people and obligations.

- Artistic leadership shapes the season and creative decisions.
- Administration handles finance, contracts, marketing and facilities.
- Technical and production staff deliver the physical event.
- Board or management oversight protects the organisation's sustainability.
- Roles can overlap in student productions, but responsibility must be written down.
- Know who can authorise spending before you spend.

Budget and break-even

A budget is a plan with assumptions you can defend.

- Fixed costs: venue, equipment hire, insurance, rights.
- Variable costs: costumes, props, printing, refreshments per performance.
- Revenue: ticket sales, sponsorship, concessions, merchandise.
- Break-even attendance equals fixed costs divided by contribution per ticket.
- Keep a contingency of roughly ten percent for surprises.
- Reconcile actuals against the budget after the production.

> **Rights are not optional**
> Performing a copyrighted play without permission exposes the production to legal action. Budget for rights from the start.

Scheduling and stage management

The stage manager is the production's communication spine.

- Work backwards from the performance date to set deadlines.
- Build a rehearsal calendar around cast availability and venue access.
- Stage manager's book: script, blocking notes, cue sheets and contact list.
- Rehearsal reports record attendance, progress and problems.
- Cue sequences for lighting, sound and scene changes must be rehearsed.
- Front-of-house plans cover ticketing, ushering, safety and accessibility.

The producer's arithmetic

Most student productions fail on arithmetic rather than talent. The core sum is simple: fixed costs divided by the contribution per ticket gives the number of tickets that must be sold before the production covers its costs. If the hall seats fewer than that number, the plan does not work and must change before rehearsals start, not after the posters go up.

Contribution per ticket is the ticket price minus the variable cost of each attendee - printing a programme, a refreshment, a comp ticket you must absorb. Fixed costs are everything you pay whether or not anyone comes: venue, rights, equipment hire, insurance, set materials. A contingency of roughly ten per cent is not padding; it is the line that stops a small surprise from cancelling a show.

Revenue is rarely only tickets. Sponsorship, concessions, merchandise and a second performance all change the arithmetic. Model each as a separate line with its own assumption, so that when one assumption fails you can see which part of the plan is now wrong.

Rights, contracts and the paperwork that protects you